declared or undeclared, and that the children she bore him, as will become evident, grew into people who were an integral part of his public life.

How authentic is the testimony of the texts which give a glimpse of Ashoka's love for a Vidisha woman, their marital residence in Ujjayini for many years, and the birth of two children to them? This interlude figures in the Sri Lankan tradition and in it the purpose of the retelling is to provide a synoptic account till the time when Ashoka's son and daughter from Devi went to Sri Lanka. The Sri Lankan scholar Ananda Guruge believes there 'was a special reason why the Sri Lankan Pali sources should have taken special care to preserve the memory of this particular phase in the life of Ashoka. It was on his way to Ujjain that Ashoka enjoyed the hospitality of the guild-chief Deva of Vedisa, met his daughter Vedisadevi and married her. The royal missionary Thera Mahinda who introduced Buddhism to Sri Lanka, and his sister Theri Sanghamitta, who brought the sacred Bodhi-tree, were both born of this relationship.'[27] It remains possible to test the veracity of this retelling by looking at them from the perspective of other allusions. That Ashoka was sent to Ujjayini seems authentic since his own edicts as emperor refer to the presence of a prince or 'kumara' at Ujjayini. A royal prince heading the administration there seems to have been normal practice, so the likelihood is that Ashoka, like his son later, administered Avanti from the city of Ujjayini.[28] A geographical logic in the textual references is also pertinent: Ashoka is shown as meeting Devi at Vidisha, and Vidisha falls on the way to Ujjayini from Pataliputra. Its description as a town ('nagaram') is a characterization of the settlement that matches what we know it to have been in Mauryan times, an urban centre of commercial repute probably integral to the larger Mauryan scheme of administration in Malwa. Vidisha's remains show a strong pre-Mauryan core going back to the mesolithic period, followed by a long phase when it was occupied by people who used stone and copper.[29] The first historic phase of occupation there is substantial and goes back to *c.* 500 BC, to a time before the